



The Minority PLAN

An enduring belief in the power of sops prompts the government to announce a slew of populist schemes for minorities. It may not be enough to get the DF a victory in the polls.

| By Aditi Pai |

With the Lok Sabha elections over and the assembly elections just around the corner, the Democratic Front (DF) Government in the state has realised that there is still some unfinished business that needs attention—wooing the minorities. Going by Election 2009 results, it is clear that the minority community has reposed faith in the Congress and Nationalist Congress Party (NCP) by choosing their candidates in 17 and eight seats re-

spectively, out of the total 48. The minority community candidates, too, have managed to bag a sizeable share of the votes: NCP's Azam Pansare got 2.8 lakh votes from Maval while Samajwadi Party candidate Abu Asim Azmi gathered over 84,000 votes in suburban Mumbai. It is this growing demand for better representation and opportunities that prompted the Congress-NCP combine to go all out to please the minorities with populist measures ahead of the assembly elections. From awarding scholarships to meritorious girl students from the mi-

norities and assistance to women's self-help groups, to doling out money for the revamp of graveyards, the DF Government is lending a helping hand in almost every sphere and in every possible manner.

These populist measures, many believe, will help the government win over the minorities which include Muslims, Christians, Sikhs, Parsis, Jains and Buddhists. Apart from disbursing Rs 110 crore from last year's unused corpus, the Minorities' Development Department (MDD) will seek an additional Rs 150 crore in this